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Semi-detached Ally? (1959–1962)

To say that the American attitude today is noticeably friendly to India in contrast to the past is to state the obvious. Our country seems to be on the uppermost level of consciousness of the internationally-minded section of Americans.… It is not enough to say that India has gained favour in American eyes because there has recently been an upsurge of military authoritarianism in West and South Asia. This no doubt has been a potent factor in shaping American attitude to India, but it is made obvious to us here that the main motivating factor in this context has been fear of China.

—M. C. Chagla, Indian ambassador to the US, 1959[1]

What has moved India toward us in the last few years? Essentially it isn't our policy or our increasing generosity in supporting India's ambitious five-year plans. It is the Chinese pressures on the northeast frontier. Over time, the conflict of interest between Peiping and Delhi will almost certainly grow rather than decrease. And sooner or later the Indians will come to realize that the arena of conflict is not only along the Himalayas but in Southeast Asia as well.

—Robert Komer, National Security Council staff, 1962[2]